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Volume No. 15 Issue No. 01 Mumbai September 2026

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Dear friends,

Thirteen years! It really doesn't feel that long ago when we put together the first issue of My Powai in September 2013. What started as a small community magazine has, over the years, become a part of Powai and Chandivali. And that is entirely because of you, our readers, contributors, advertisers and well wishers. Thank you!

This anniversary issue comes at a time when the festive season is upon us. Our Diet page looks at how we can enjoy all the festive goodies without ending up with a food hangover. After all, festivals are meant to be enjoyed, but perhaps not at the cost of our waistlines! On the Recipe page, Sherry Bhatnagar takes us to Kerala with a closer look at the traditional Sadhya, along with some authentic recipes. If you love food, this one is definitely worth trying. Our Astro page tells you what the stars have in store, while our Local News keeps you updated on what is happening around Powai and Chandivali.

And since August was all about celebrating Independence Day, we bring you pictures from celebrations across the neighbourhood. The Tricolour was everywhere and the spirit was infectious.

Thirteen years would not have been possible without your support. So, from all of us at My Powai, a heartfelt thank you. Here's to 13 years and many more! Happy Reading!

Warm regards,

Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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Teeing off, together

The thriving society in Powai has many groups with special interests. There are groups for jogging, cycling, yoga, singing, dancing, et al. Among all these, there is a unique group of golf aficionados.

Started in 2015 by residents of Jal Vayu Vihar, this group has grown into a well-knit community of golfers and their families. In the initial days, it was Commodore Vijay Vaid who encouraged individual golfers to join as a group and play together. This system caught on, as golfers by nature are like-minded, and travelling together in a carpool made life a lot simpler.

Somewhat in line with the legendary US-based golfing fraternity, the group is informally known as the PGA (Powai Golf Association). A very active and committed group, they travel within the country to play golf at different locations and plan one trip abroad each year. Golf is notorious for men leaving their families behind for long hours and, hence, is not always much liked on the home front. In this case, however, families are very much involved in the group, with fun-filled social events and tours.

Members play golf four times a week and take their game seriously. Captain Jasbir Singh is the most well-known champion player in the group. He won the DRS League 2026 tournament held recently and took home the Green Jacket. Wg. Cdr. Chris Chatterjee plays with the group regularly at Bombay Presidency Golf Club and was selected as the Golfer of the Year by the club. Commodore Mike Bada continues to play at the age of 87 and is a great inspiration to many. There are a few others, like VAdm. SKK Krishnan, who are equally competitive and take part in various tournaments.

The PGA conducts an annual golf tournament and invites friends from other cities. Serious golf is played over two days at different courses in Mumbai, with prizes given to the winners. On such occasions, quite a few golfers from Mumbai are invited to join. Ladies are also encouraged to participate through a special putting competition, and quite often, the lady does better than her golfing husband!

In these rainy days, when golfing is somewhat curtailed, the group celebrated its Raising Day over breakfast at the Westin Powai Hotel on the lakeside. All the ladies joined in and, as usual, it was great fun.

In the twilight years of life, golf has become a great source of physical and mental wellness. The average age of the group is above 72, and yet they walk with a spring in their step and their posture erect. Occasionally, you might see someone practising an imaginary swing while standing in line at the local market. You can rest assured that this would be a PGA member.

An evening of ghazals: Surur-e-Ghazal

Let's Sing Studio at Saki Vihar organised a musical programme on ghazals titled "Surur-e-Ghazal." The singers chose ghazals by famous composers and lyricists who were proficient in shayari or Urdu verses.

The ghazals beautifully expressed a range of emotions and pain experienced by people in different situations and relationships, including love, separation and longing.

The nuances of ghazals were explained by a member, Vivek Satpute. The shayari of renowned poets such as Mirza Ghalib and Bahadur Shah Zafar was featured, with ghazals made famous by legends such as Begum Akhtar, Ghulam Ali and Jagjit Singh, to name a few.

The ghazals presented included "Rasm-e-Ulfat," "Haal-e-Dil Unko Sunaya," "Dikhai Diye Yun," "Hoshwalon Ko Khabar," "Rang Aur Noor Ki," "Dil Cheez Kya Hai" and "Jhuki Jhuki Si Nazar," among others.

Member Amita Babu compered the programme very artistically, while another member, Prakash Nanavati, managed the finances meticulously. Studio owner Manoj Dev managed the sound system to the satisfaction of the singers.

Hot tea and snacks were served to keep the energy flowing. A well-known guest singer from Powai also presented some special numbers.

A group photograph was taken to preserve the memories of the evening. Those wishing to join the group may contact Manoj Dev at 9820293174.

- Preeti Oka

BMC stalls new projects in Powai - prioritize projects in hand.

D.P.K. Udas

The new Municipal Commissioner has given the directive to "priority for projects in hand". This is due to core fiscal strategy of the BMC.

Facing massive long-term infrastructure commitments, the BMC has explicitly shifted its focus away from announcing fresh new projects.

Even those who have been planned have been put on hold. Now this is going to affect Powai as none of the ongoing projects are in this area. Why BMC is Prioritizing "Projects in Hand"?

- **Massive Committed Liabilities:** The BMC operates under massive future commitments, with a combined balance project cost exceeding ₹2.32 lakh crore for ongoing schemes.

- **FD Mobilization:** In the BMC FY26-27 Budget, the corporation earmarked ₹48,164 crore (nearly 60%) toward Capital Expenditure, dipping into its fixed deposits to fund these ongoing obligations rather than stalling them.

- **Shelving Secondary Ideas:** To protect its financial health, the civic body has scaled down or shelved several side-projects from previous years (such as the "Mumbai Eye" tourism project to keep funds locked into critical utility works.

The BMC's current capital push focuses on following Projects.

- **Wastewater Treatment Facility (WWTF):** Upgrading and constructing seven massive Sewage Treatment Plants (STPs) across the city to overhaul the sewage system and generate recycled water.

- **Mega Road Concretization:** A multi-phase project covering 700 km of city roads to create durable, pothole-free surfaces. The BMC aims for complete execution by December 2026.

- **Mumbai Coastal Road Project (MCRP):** Fast-tracking the northern extensions (Versova – Dahisar – Bhayander Link Road) to dramatically ease vehicular congestion in the suburbs.

- **Goregaon–Mulund Link Road (GMLR):** Accelerating the execution of the twin tunnels to significantly reduce east-west travel times by 2028–2029.

- **Water Supply Augmentation:** Expediting major water conveyance systems, the Gargai Dam in Palghar, and the Manori Desalination Plant to secure long-term drinking water infrastructure for Mumbai.

Powai/Chandivali area had following projects under implementation or at planning stage. These have been put on back burner now.

1) Beautification of Under Pass at L&T flyover by erecting vertical garden.

2) Underpass at EEH for right turn towards Powai for vehicles coming from Mulund side.

3) Creation of the Auditorium & Multipurpose hall.

4) 100 bed Municipal Hospital at Sangharsh Nagar.

5) Channelizing rain water gushing down from Powai Hills.

6) Creation of Play Grounds and maintaining open spaces.

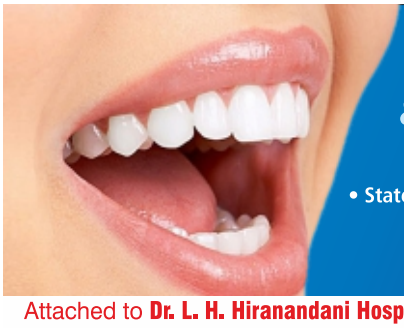
7) CAAOMS – Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring System.

8) Sky Walk at Rumbaugh & IIT Metro stations.

9) Fire Stations.

These developmental projects are not likely to see the beginning as Mega Projects are going to suck funds and also time.

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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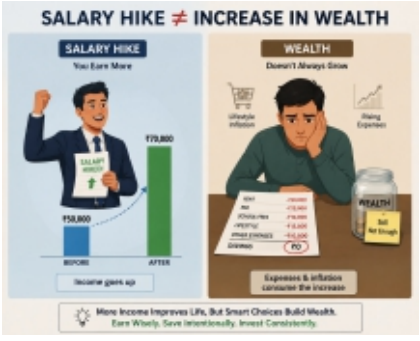
Your salary got a raise. Did your wealth?

"Congratulations! Your salary has been revised."

He read the email twice.
The raise was good. Very good.
He called his wife. They celebrated over dinner and, as often happens after a salary hike, the conversation moved to what they could now afford.
Perhaps a better car. Perhaps that holiday they had postponed. Perhaps finally upgrading the house.
Nothing extravagant. Just a few things that felt deserved after years of hard work.
Two years passed.
There was another promotion. Another salary increase. Another round of small upgrades.
One evening, while looking at a family photograph, his wife casually asked,
"When do you think we can actually afford to stop worrying about money?"
He laughed.
Then he paused.
He knew exactly how much he earned. He knew his monthly expenses. He had investments, insurance and a home loan.
But he couldn't answer her question.
Not because they were doing badly.
They were doing quite well.
They had simply never stopped to look at the bigger picture.



THE QUESTION BEHIND THE PAYSLIP
We know our salary.
We know our EMIs.
We know roughly how much we invest.
But do we know whether all these pieces are taking us towards the life we want?
A salary hike can certainly make today more comfortable. But it can also quietly create an opportunity for tomorrow.
A little more towards the home you've been dreaming about.
A little more towards your child's future.
A little more towards financial freedom.
A little more towards the retirement you imagine.
There is no magic percentage. No single formula works for every family.
Because the right financial decision for one person may be completely wrong for another.
That is why sometimes the most useful financial question isn't:
"Where should I invest?"
It is:
"Where am I today, where do I want to go, and am I on the right path?"
You may already be earning well. You may already be investing regularly. You may even have several financial products.
But if nobody has ever put the entire picture together for you, you may be missing something important.
So, when your next salary hike arrives, celebrate it.
And then take a moment to ask:
"Did my wealth get a raise too?"
If you aren't sure, perhaps that's a conversation worth having.

- Uma Kumaravelan
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7 errors that can cost you your property ownership

Ashmi Pradhan

An unclear property title can result in long drawn legal battles, financial losses & inability to transfer property, often caused by legal oversight & paperwork mistakes.

Error #1: Will/Probate/ Administration Bond directly leads to inheritance

It is a common misconception that a Will/ Probate/ Administration Bond directly transfers property ownership.

Every transfer of property ownership is subject to the key legal process of "Estate Administration" which involves asset location & valuation, property management, payment of testamentary expenses & settlement of debts, loans, liabilities & taxes, & finally distribution of remaining assets in the estate.

The immovable properties are transferred by the Executor/ Administrator to beneficiaries named in the Will, or to legal heirs under the personal succession laws through a written & registered instrument known as Assent/ Deed of Transfer.

Error #2: Exclusion of Mortgagee Bank in purchase of a Mortgaged Property

Any private sale accompanied by delivery of physical possession of a mortgaged property without approval & involvement of the Mortgagee bank is legally invalid & detrimental to the buyer. While such unauthorised sale is invalid against the Mortgagee bank, the buyer does not acquire property title. If the seller defaults in clearing the outstanding loan in full from the money received from property sale, the buyer also loses possession & money paid.

To obtain clear & valid title to the mortgaged property, the Mortgagee Bank's involvement is crucial at every stage of sale transaction including issue of Bank NOC at pre-sale, execution of Tripartite Agreement & direct transfer of sale proceeds by buyer to the Mortgagee Bank for loan closure during sale, & issue of Release Deed, Loan Closure Statement, Charge Cancellation Letter, No Dues Certificate, & release of original property documents at post-sale.

Error #3: Registered document of sale automatically confers property ownership

A registered sale by itself does not automatically/ conclusively guarantee property ownership. While registration is a mandatory procedural requirement to validate a sale transaction, ownership depends upon whether the seller has a clear & lawful title to transfer the property. Registration serves as a public record of the transaction & cannot fix defective/ disputed title.

The ownership of property is collectively determined by factors like chain of title, property records, actual possession, & lawful execution & registration of documents. A comprehensive title investigation before registration becomes essential to ascertain whether ownership of the property is complete & free from encumbrances.

Error #4: MoU/ Agreement to sell does not require registration

A written & signed but unregistered MoU/ Agreement to Sell might be sufficient to book a property for future, however, an unregistered property document does not guarantee protection against third-party claims & title disputes. The seller might – fraudulently sell the property to another buyer/ refuse to proceed with final sale.

A registered document creates a formal record of the transaction, serves as a notice to the public at large, & acts as legal shield against any adverse property transactions.

Error #5: Mutation transfers property ownership

Mutation entries of a property in municipal or land revenue records only updates government & local body property records, fixes the legal responsibility of payment of statutory taxes, & aids in application for utility connections. Mutation by itself does not create/ transfer/ extinguish a legal title.

Documents which create valid title in property are Sale Deed/ Gift Deed/ Exchange Deed for separate property, Partition Deed for joint/ ancestral/ HUF property, & Deed of Transfer for inheritance/ trust-owned property.

Error #6: Waiver is sufficient to give up property rights

An informal, written & generic document signed by a co-owner consenting to waive their property rights does not legally extinguish their property rights. A simple waiver falls short of mandatory legal requirements for validity of such property transaction.

Every valid transaction for giving up a share in property ownership must be – in writing, in the form of a Relinquishment Deed/ Release Deed executed in favour of other co-owner(s), contain explicit language of absolute ownership surrender, properly stamped & mandatorily registered.

Error #7: Vacating property/ stopping payments automatically cancels a registered tenancy/ lease/ license

Walking out of a transaction without formal paperwork or an eviction decree to end a registered tenancy/ lease/ license creates a cloud on title & restricts smooth property transfer. The old tenant/ lessee/ licensee might continue claiming rights under the registered agreement while a new occupant/ buyer may sue you for breach of contract due to fraud.

If the parties to a registered tenancy/ lease/ license mutually agree to an early exit, then execution & registration of a 'Surrender Deed' for tenancy/ lease or a 'Cancellation Deed' for license followed by handover of possession & settlement of dues is essential to prevent ongoing legal liability, close encumbrances, & clear title in property records.

(Ashmi Pradhan is a licenced legal practitioner dual-qualified as Advocate in India & Solicitor in England & Wales with a decade of experience in private practice. She specialises in domestic & cross-border civil, commercial & private wealth law. You can get in touch with her on +91-9004704342 or at ashmipradhan01@outlook.com)

Independence Day celebration

Blue Haven, Raheja Vihar

Lilium Lantana

Synchronicity

Symphony

Sovereign, Hiranandani Gardens

Orchid Enclave, Nahar Amrit Shakti

Independence Day celebration

Arum - Alamanda, Nahar Aamrit Shakti

Eldora, Hiranandani Gardens

Magnolia, Nahar Amrit Shakti

Independence Day celebration

Maple, Raheja Vihar

Brentwood, Hiranandani Gardens

Panch Smruti Celebrates India's 80th Independence Day with Pride and Enthusiasm

Panch Smruti, a residential community in Powai, Mumbai, celebrated the 80th Independence Day of India with great enthusiasm, patriotic spirit and participation from residents and their families.

The celebrations commenced with the flag-hoisting ceremony, which was attended by Shri Dadasaheb Ghutukade, Assistant Commissioner of Police, Mumbai Police, as the Chief Guest. The national flag was hoisted with due honour, followed by the National Anthem and individual performances by the kids.

The event brought together residents across age groups and created a strong sense of community, unity and patriotism. The programme continued with an engaging session of entertainment, games and activities for children, youngsters and adults.

A special highlight of the celebrations was the performance by renowned ventriloquist artist Suchitra Indulkar, which was thoroughly enjoyed by the audience. The entertainment programme also featured patriotic beats, fun activities and individual performances by residents, making the occasion lively and memorable for everyone.

Snacks were served to residents during the entertainment programme, followed by a community lunch for residents and guests,

The Managing Committee of Panch Smruti expressed its gratitude to Shri Dadasaheb Ghutukade, ACP, Mumbai Police, for graciously attending the celebrations as the Chief Guest and encouraging the residents. The Committee also thanked all residents, volunteers and participants whose enthusiastic involvement made the Independence Day celebration a grand success.

The celebrations concluded with a renewed commitment to the values of freedom, unity, harmony and community spirit, with residents coming together to celebrate the pride of being Indians.

Jai Hind!

- Managing Committee
Panch Smruti

The six seconds between a trigger and a response

Debika Chaudhuri

Have you ever received a message and felt your body react before you had even finished reading it?

Perhaps it is from a colleague, a partner, a friend or someone at home.

"You really need to get this right next time. I can't keep correcting these mistakes."

You read several times, and something inside you tightens. "How dare they speak to me like that?"

Your fingers move quickly. Before you have had time to think, you type: **"Maybe you should learn how to communicate properly before criticising someone else's work."** And you press **send.**

A few minutes later, you may regret the words. But by then, the conversation has taken a different direction.

This is what makes emotional triggers so interesting.

The trigger may be outside us. But what happens next is not entirely outside our control.

The same trigger can take us in very different directions

That one message can evoke different emotions in different people.

For one person, it may trigger **anger.** For another, **fear.** Someone else may feel **hurt, anxious** or **disappointed.** And each emotion can produce a different behaviour.

When anger takes over

You might respond:

"Maybe you should learn how to communicate properly before criticising someone else's work."

You become sharp. You challenge the person. Perhaps you carry the irritation into the next meeting and become argumentative.

The original issue, perhaps a genuine mistake in the work, gets lost. Now there are two problems: **the mistake and the relationship.**

When fear takes over

You might respond:

"I'm sorry. I'll make sure this never happens again."

But inside, something else is happening. You begin checking everything repeatedly. You seek approval before making decisions. You become afraid of making another mistake. Over time, you may become slower and less confident. The feedback that was meant to improve your work has inadvertently begun to affect your sense of competence.

When hurt takes over

You might say: "I was only trying to help. If you think I'm so incompetent, perhaps you should do it yourself." You feel misunderstood and attacked. So you withdraw. You stop sharing ideas. You speak less in meetings. You keep your distance from the

person. The other person may not even realise how deeply their words affected you. Yet the relationship begins to change.

When anxiety takes over

Your response might be: "What exactly did I get wrong? Is there something else I've missed? Can you please check the whole thing?" You go back to the document. Then again. Then once more. You ask for reassurance. Now, the work takes longer. Your anxiety grows. The other person becomes frustrated.

When disappointment takes over

You might simply say: "Fine. I'll just do what I'm told." And slowly, you disengage. You stop volunteering ideas. You participate less. You do only what is explicitly asked of you.

The person who sent the original message may now see you as uncooperative or uninterested, when in reality you are feeling undervalued.

One trigger. Five possible emotional journeys.

And this is why emotional intelligence is not simply about knowing the names of our emotions.

It is about understanding **what those emotions are doing to our thinking and behaviour.**

So where does the six-second pause come in?

There is a little space between what happens to us and what we do next. Only six seconds.

But those six seconds can create a choice.

You read the same message:

"You really need to get this right next time. I can't keep correcting these mistakes."

You feel the anger. You notice your body tightening. You want to respond immediately.

Instead, you pause.

Breathe.

Six seconds.

Not to suppress the anger. Not to convince yourself that the other person is right. Not to become artificially calm. Just enough time to ask yourself:

What am I feeling?

I'm angry. And perhaps I'm embarrassed too.

What am I telling myself?

They think I'm incompetent.

What do I actually know?

They are unhappy about repeated mistakes. I don't know yet whether they are deliberately attacking me.

What do I want to achieve?

I want to address the problem without damaging the relationship—and I also want respectful communication.

Now the response changes.

Perhaps you say:

"I understand that the errors are frustrating. I'd like to understand exactly what needs to be corrected so I can address the issue. At the same time, I'd appreciate it if we could discuss it without making it personal."

You become increasingly aware of **what happens between the trigger and the response.**

Because that is where our choice lies.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

KSV celebrates Independence Day with a difference

The Independence Day at Kanakia Silicon Valley (KSV) was celebrated with a great deal of enthusiasm but this year there was a lovely twist to the proceedings. Instead of following the traditional practice of having an ex serviceman or a senior citizen hoist the Tricolour, KSV decided to hand over the honour to its youngest residents. The children proudly hoisted the national flag, followed by the national anthem.

And then the stage belonged to the children. Eleven breathtaking performances followed, each one bringing a different kind of energy to the celebration. The amount of preparation was evident but what stood out was the confidence with which the children performed.

Every performance was greeted with thunderous applause and the patriotic songs were particularly special. There were moments when the singing and performances gave the audience goosebumps. The children had clearly decided that Independence Day deserved nothing less than their very best.

What I particularly loved was the spirit behind the entire celebration. Independence Day is not only about remembering those who fought for our freedom. It is also about giving the next generation a sense of belonging and pride in the country they will inherit. By allowing the children to hoist the flag and then giving them the stage, KSV did exactly that. They were not merely watching the celebration. They were the celebration.

Once the performances came to an end, it was time for refreshments. Residents gathered around, enjoyed the food and caught up with friends and neighbours before slowly making their way home. There was the usual chatter, plenty of smiles and perhaps a little tiredness among the children who had given their all on stage. It was a relaxed and happy end to a morning that had been packed with energy.

What an amazing way to celebrate Independence Day. The Tricolour was proudly hoisted, the national anthem brought everyone together, eleven wonderful performances entertained and inspired the audience and the children showed us that patriotism can be expressed with enthusiasm, confidence and joy.

For a community like KSV, it was more than an event. It was a morning that brought everyone together and left behind memories that will last a lifetime.

-Urvashi Ranga

The gut feeling is real: what the gut-brain axis means for student anxiety

Most students know the feeling. Your stomach hurts before an exam, you lose your appetite during a stressful week, or you suddenly feel nauseous right before giving a presentation. We usually call it “nerves” or “butterflies,” but there is actually a scientific explanation for why stress can affect the stomach so strongly.

The gut and the brain are connected through what scientists call the gut-brain axis. It is basically a two-way communication system between the digestive system and the brain. This means that when we are stressed, our brain can affect our stomach, but what is happening in our gut can also affect how we feel mentally.

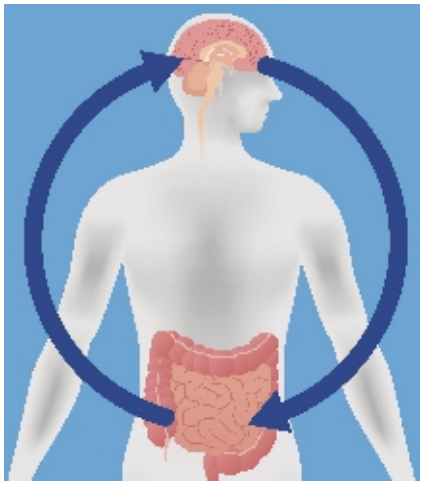
The digestive system even has its own network of nerve cells, called the enteric nervous system. It contains millions of neurons and is sometimes referred to as the body’s “second brain.” One of the main ways it communicates with the brain is through the vagus nerve, which runs from the brainstem down to organs in the body, including the stomach and intestines.

Another important part of this connection is the gut microbiome, which is made up of trillions of bacteria and other microorganisms living in the digestive system. These bacteria help break down food and support the immune system, but researchers have also found that they can influence chemicals connected to mood and stress.

For example, most of the body's serotonin is produced in the digestive system. Serotonin is involved in many processes, including digestion and mood regulation. Gut bacteria can also influence chemicals such as GABA and dopamine, which are connected to stress, emotions, and motivation. This does not mean that our stomachs completely control our feelings, but it does show that mental and physical health are more connected than they might seem.

This connection can be especially noticeable for students. During exam season, routines often become completely different. Students may sleep less, drink more coffee, skip meals, eat more packaged or fried food, and spend long hours sitting and studying. At the same time, stress levels are usually much higher.

All of this can affect digestion. Stress hormones can change the way food moves through the digestive system, which is why some people experience nausea, stomach pain, constipation, or frequent trips to the bathroom when they are anxious. A student may feel completely normal during the holidays and then suddenly start having stomach problems when exams begin.



This can be even more common for students with packed schedules. In cities like Mumbai, for example, students may have school, coaching classes, long commutes, and late-night study sessions all in the same day. Meals can become irregular, and convenience foods may be easier to grab than balanced meals. Over time, these habits can affect both the digestive system and the bacteria living in the gut.

Diet also plays a role in gut health. Foods that are rich in fibre, such as vegetables, fruits, lentils and whole grains, help feed beneficial gut bacteria. Fermented foods can also support the microbiome. Interestingly, many traditional Indian foods already include fermentation. Dahi, idli and dosa are common examples.

This does not mean that eating a bowl of curd before an exam will suddenly remove anxiety. The gut-brain connection is much more complicated than that. However, regularly eating a balanced diet may help support both digestive health and the body’s ability to deal with stress.

Scientists are also studying something called psychobiotics, which are specific probiotics that may affect mood through the gut-brain connection. The research is interesting, but it is still developing. At the moment, probiotics should not be treated as a cure for anxiety or as a replacement for professional mental health support.

Simple habits can still make a difference. Eating meals at fairly regular times, getting enough sleep, staying hydrated and avoiding too much caffeine can help the body stay more balanced. Exercise, walking and breathing exercises may also reduce stress, which can help calm digestive symptoms.

Of course, this does not mean that anxiety is caused only by poor gut health. Students deal with real pressures, including exams, competition, family expectations and lack of sleep. Serious anxiety cannot simply be fixed by changing your diet.

What the gut-brain axis does show is that mental health is not only “in the head.” Stress can create real physical changes in the body, especially in the digestive system. At the same time, the condition of the gut may affect how well the body handles stress.

So the next time your stomach starts acting up before an exam, it may not just be random. That uncomfortable “gut feeling” could actually be your brain and digestive system reacting to each other.

- Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
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Footnotes

On desire paths, deeds, and everything else in Powai that was only ever secured by habit.

Chaarvi Athawale

There's a word for the kind of paths I grew up walking in Powai, though I only learned it recently, in an entirely different context. Landscape architects call it a desire path, the trail that appears across a stretch of grass not because anyone designed it, but because enough feet crossed it the same way, often enough, that the ground gave in and remembered. No architect draws a desire path. No committee approves it. It exists purely because people kept choosing it, over and over, until the choosing became the path.

I didn't know the word as a child. I only knew that the stretch of pavement past the trees, down towards Heritage Garden, was simply there, the way the sky was there, the way my grandmother's hand was there before she let go of it a little further each week. Once I learned the phrase, I couldn't stop finding it everywhere here, because almost nothing I grew up loving about Powai was ever actually secured. It was walked, looked at, used, often enough that we mistook the habit for a guarantee.

The sky was the first desire path. I used to see a real stretch of it from the garden, uninterrupted, the kind you could lie back and lose an hour in. Nobody signed anything promising me that view, it existed because the land in front of it happened to be low, for a while, and I grew up in front of the window before it wasn't. A tower went up, then eleven more, and the sky didn't disappear so much as get redistricted, parcelled out floor by floor to whoever bought the right to stand in front of it first. I don't think anyone did anything illegal. I think I finally understood that a view was never mine to lose, because it was never mine to keep.

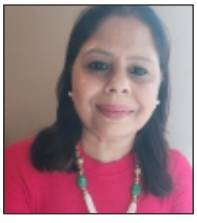
The pavement adjoining Citipark property is the version of this that's currently in writing, which is what makes it the clearest case rather than the only one. A stretch of footpath outside a new redevelopment on Central Avenue, turns out, on paper, to belong to the plot rather than the public. A barricade has gone up along it, flowerpots have appeared on the walkway across the road for good measure, and when residents asked how one of Powai's busiest commercial streets could have been approved without public footpaths on either side, the answer that came back was a document, not an apology: “all works undertaken”, the company said, “in accordance with the requisite statutory approvals.”

Several years of feet on one side. A survey record on the other. There is already a Supreme Court directive calling for pavements on both sides of every road. So far, that hasn't moved the flowerpots. The roads underneath all of this are a quieter casualty, not fenced, just overwhelmed, built for a neighbourhood's worth of happy steps and now intended to carry a business district's worth of cabs and delivery riders. Nobody barricaded the road. It simply stopped holding what it was never surveyed to hold, the way a desire path can vanish not because someone blocks it but because too many feet suddenly need somewhere else to go.

Here's what I think all of this, underneath the different paperwork: none of it was ever really a fight between residents and commerce. It was a fight between two kinds of claim. First, the kind you earn by using something long enough that it starts to feel like yours, and the kind you buy, which doesn't need to feel like anything, only to be filed correctly. For most of my childhood here, the first kind was enough. Lately it isn't, not because residents stopped using the place, but because everyone finally noticed that using was never the same as owning, and started asking, plot by plot, for the paperwork to catch up.

I don't know how the pavement dispute resolves, or the next one after it. I know a path worn by decades of feet isn't undocumented, it's written in a language a deed doesn't read yet. Deeds get redrawn. Companies rename themselves. The sky gets sold off one floor at a time. But someone is still walking that stretch of Central Avenue every evening, flowerpots or not, the same way I did at seven, before anyone told me I needed permission. I'd like to see the paperwork that ends that.

Shades of Freedom: Beyond the Tricolour



Girija Menon

August 15, every year brings a vibrant wave of patriotism in every part of our country. Feeds overflow with images of the tricolour, flag-hoisting ceremonies, inspiring quotes, and heartfelt tributes to Indian independence. Orange, white, and green form the core of our collective pride, but national freedom is only the opening chapter of a much larger, story. True freedom comes in countless shades, evolving with every stage of life for every individual. If one had to start from the very beginning, the flow is seamless.

The Early Years: It began with the simple, basic joy of turning in the final exam paper in school—the pure bliss of endless summer afternoons ahead. Plans that were so innocent yet felt like bliss - planning to execution

Young Adulthood: Independence evolved into the liberty of choice – graduation and after. Picking a career path, choosing to study further, or packing bags for a university across the globe. So many plans here but an informed path is what works best – planning to execution.

Financial Autonomy: Few feelings match the unique high of that first pay check. It brings the power to live life on one's own terms, make personal choices, and decide on how one wants to take forward this journey – alone or with someone special. Freedom to choose.

Parenthood & Career: Freedom to follow nuances of modern parenting if one decides to become a parent. Making informed choices from books, forums, and conscious awareness rather than blind tradition.

At the workplace, it is the authority to make key decisions, switch streams mid-career, and navigate hurdles under adverse conditions, turning professional uncertainties into triumphs.

The Golden Chapters: Post-retirement freedom offers the ultimate liberation. Hobbies long locked in an old suitcase finally get to breathe. Whether it means traveling, spending time with grandchildren, or simply resting, this stage brings the freedom of no longer needing to prove anything or compete with anyone.

Life's freedom isn't a single flat hue; it is a dynamic spectrum—some solid colours, some gentle gradients, and occasionally, a totally blank canvas waiting to be painted. Each individual carries a unique "freedom quotient." A canvas so personal that the shades that fill the canvas come from the heart's palette.

The true beauty of freedom lies in honouring those differences—allowing everyone's unique journey to thrive, bloom, and coexist. As another Independence Day passes, taking a moment to cherish every shade of personal freedom is what makes the journey truly worthwhile.

(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)

The relationship paradox

More connectivity, less intimacy (Part 1)

Palak Sardana

The longest-running study on adult development at Harvard, spanning more than eight decades, arrived at a conclusion both startling in its simplicity and profound in its implications; that more than anything else, our health, happiness & longevity are influenced by the quality of our relationships. Beyond status, fame and wealth; beyond even the disciplined rituals of exercise regimes and healthy eating, it is the warmth, security, & dependability of our human connections that emerges as one of the most powerful determinants of how well and meaningfully we live.

And yet, relationships—the very backbone of wholistic human existence—have rarely been simple to navigate. Our ancient epics displayed the complexity of relationships sans the vocabulary of modern psychology eons back. The Ramayana and Mahabharata are, in many ways, magnificent laboratories of human relationships, displaying the high voltage emotional dynamics of love, loyalty, pride, insecurity, anger, greed, attachment & jealousy. They reveal how the collision of obstinate egos can become the first domino in a cascade of devastating consequences. Kaikeyi, Surpanakha and Ravana in the Ramayana; Dhritarashtra, Duryodhana and Karna in the Mahabharata—each, in their own way, becomes entangled with the negative inner forces distorting judgement, destroying relationships & causing large scale destruction.

In current times, the unprecedented leaps in technology have facilitated easy accessibility to each other like never before. We can reach out to anyone in the world at the click of a button or decide to set a date with a swipe. Connections can be initiated, sustained & called off (many times unceremoniously by 'ghosting') effortlessly, without much accountability.

While means to connect have evolved fast, the inner human apparatus that forges and steers relationships hasn't changed much. Relationships thrive on love, care, attention, and emotional availability. It requires us to focus on the other. A solid relationship brews over time, like fine tea.

Our environment too isn't supportive to nourish strong & steady relationships. Prof Jay Van Bavel, a professor of psychology & neural science at NYU has identified growing personal stress, social fragmentation, popularity of digital platforms, weakened social norms & constant exposure to conflict in our environment as factors that are making us meaner and more self-centred. A case in point is the normalisation of aggressive behaviour in popular media, where shouting, humiliation, manipulation and mind games are frequently packaged as entertainment. Repeated exposure can gradually blur the boundary between what is attention-grabbing and what is socially acceptable.

When audacious behaviours that lack civility & 'me first' policy' trickles down into inter-personal relationships, their fragility starts to show up. Emotional volatility, instability & unpredictability can completely destroy relationships.

A number of studies show dwindling trends of both dating and marriage. Youngsters around the world are either refraining to enter the dating scene or the ones who are testing waters, are often commitment phobic or fence sitters engaging in casual flings. Japan offers one of the clearest illustrations of this shift. A substantial proportion of never-married Japanese youth are either not in relationships or not particularly interested in pursuing one The scale of loneliness has even created a market for simulated companionship. Relations can be rented in Japan where people hire family members, friends or romantic partners to temporarily perform these roles, sometimes according to carefully scripted scenarios. The 2025 film Rental Family draws on this real-world phenomenon and explores loneliness and manufactured intimacy.

Gradual collapse of marriage with more people getting divorced than ever and lesser and lesser people wanting to marry, the smallest social structure of the society seems to be losing its position as the default structure of adult life, becoming a high-investment, high-selectivity relationship institution.

These trends have led to many new terminologies being coined by relationship experts from hook-ups to situationships & benching to orbiting just to name a few. For the uninitiated, these modern dating terms describe either the structure of the arrangement and/or the emotional dynamics with in it.

These increasingly diverse and fluid arrangements can be liberating in their responsiveness to individual needs. But freedom of choice does not automatically translate into emotional security. Ambiguity, disposability, weak commitment and chronic uncertainty can carry psychological costs of loneliness and emotional distress.

We cannot stop relationships from evolving or cease the socio-cultural, political and economic effects from reshaping them. But we can cultivate personal capacities and acquire tools needed to navigate the increasingly complex terrain of human relationships.

In this series, we will explore timeless wisdom and contemporary insights from psychology, neuroscience, philosophy and lived experience to help us build these capacities. The world may continue to redefine what relationships look like, but it cannot change our fundamental need to belong, be understood and experience deep, authentic connection. The forms may change; the human longing for connection & support won't.

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Festive eating without the food hangover

Nisha Singh

The Great Indian Festival season has begun. Shravan, Teej, Onam, Parsi New year, Raksha Bandhan and Ganesh Chaturthi and more are either done or just around the corner. In Indian homes, during festivals, food is not just nourishment, it is a celebration. It is hospitality, tradition, and a reason for spending time with friends and family.

How do you enjoy this season, guilt - free and without derailing your health and fitness?

Simply, by not making this into a calorie - counting affair. Instead, choose wisely, keeping moderation and balance in mind.

The trick is to enjoy the whole festival season and not to make each meal a festival in itself.

- **Eat before a party -** The simplest way to avoid eating too much or indulging in rich foods is to never enter a pooja or party on an empty stomach. This is what people most often ignore. Most people think that since there is a party to attend, and there will obviously be festive food in the buffet, they should avoid food the rest of the day to balance out the calories. However, the issue is that your biology does not support this thought. Since you have arrived at the party practically ravenous, your senses are going to be heightened. The sight and smell of food is going to add to the sense of hunger. The likelihood of eating quickly, taking bigger portions, and reaching for whatever is immediately available is higher. This action completely negates the effort. Instead, eat normally throughout the day and choose wisely during the event. Always step out after eating a small snack.

- **Build your fun, festive plate -** Instead of worrying about calories and rich food, enjoy the spread. Fill your plate with a protein source to begin with, and then build around it. Do not fill the plate with everything available. The ask is not to make the festival spread feel like a regular day's food. Instead, choose what you really want to eat. And enjoy it. Completely. Not riddled with guilt. That damages the metabolism even more. Just remember that what matters is the overall pattern.

- **Choose beverages wisely -** The bulk of hidden sugar is found mostly in beverages. Avoid packaged juices, milkshakes, aerated drinks, and sweetened mocktails. Opt for unsweetened lime soda, sparkling water, or stick to plain water instead. Leave the sweet quota for an actual sweet that you want to savour. If consuming alcohol, indulge responsibly and ensure that you drink a glass of plain water in between.

- **Sweets and fried foods are not forbidden -** Mithais and fried snacks are the core of most Indian festivals. Every laddoo, modak and samosa feels tempting and irresistible. Don't say no to all of them. Rather, think about which one you really want. And relish it thoroughly. Choose one each from the sweet and savoury categories. This helps avoid grazing on them the whole day. When you graze, you think that since you are just taking a bite or two of each, it will not harm. That you are not consuming the entire food item. When the fact is that grazing on several items increases the consumption of processed sugars and trans fats anyway without giving you any satisfaction. Just remember that frequency matters. One sweet or one fried snack is not unhealthy. And try to keep it that way. Balance them by choosing healthier options for the rest of the meal.

- **Keep the next day normal -** The most common mistake made is that the day after an indulgent meal or even an indulgent meal day is considered as the "punishment" day. Please do not make this mistake. Eat normally the next day, as you would on any other day. "Punishing" yourself with juice fasts, and cleanse days, or exercising "extra" are all in fact more unhealthy for your metabolism. It is wiser to maintain a regular schedule the following day. Choose simple, healthy meals, hydrate yourself well, maintain your exercise schedule, and sleep on time. Your body is very smart and has its own mechanisms - the liver and kidneys - that are already working on cleansing and detoxifying the body. They will help you get your body back on track.

- **Give your digestion a little help -** Large, heavy, fat, and sugar- rich meals leave the digestion a little sluggish. Bloating, Acidity, constipation, water retention, puffy eyes are all a possibility. To avoid them, it is important that you - Eat slowly. Take a little pause between the two servings. Sip on warm water. Put your plate down when you feel a little bit full. Stroll for ten minutes post meals. This is not about compensating for indulgence. This is being mindful. This is balance.

In my opinion,the most important shift in mindset that is needed is that - health is shaped by patterns, not by a single meal, festive or otherwise.

Enjoy the celebrations. And return to routine in the next meal.

Remember - Balance always.

We at My Powai are taking our readers' queries related to Diet & Nutrition, which Ms. Nisha Singh will reply to in our forthcoming issues.

You can send your questions at: dietnutrition.queries@gmail.com

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

From the sadya to your table: the journey continues

Sherry Bhatnagar

Last time, we followed Kerala's Onam morning into the heart of a traditional Sadya. Now, the feast moves from the banana leaf to our kitchens. Avial, Pineapple Pachadi, Pal Payasam and Appam take centre stage, bringing with them familiar aromas, cherished traditions and a few kitchen secrets. So, let's continue the journey—and discover how Kerala's magic can come alive at our own tables.

Pal Payasam — The Sweet Heart of a Kerala Feast:

Ingredients | Serves 4

- 1 litre full-fat milk
- ¼ cup raw rice, preferably small-grained
- ¾ cup sugar
- 2–3 green cardamom pods, lightly crushed — optional
- 1 tbsp cashews — optional
- 1 tbsp raisins — optional

Cooking Instructions: Wash and drain the rice. Bring milk to a gentle boil, add rice and simmer slowly, stirring frequently as the milk reduces and thickens. Scrape the milk solids from the sides and stir them in for richness. Add sugar and cook for 10–15 minutes until glossy. Add crushed cardamom, if desired; cashews and raisins are optional. Remove from heat, rest briefly and serve. The secret? Patience—keep the flame low and let milk, rice and sugar slowly work their magic.

Pineapple Pachadi — a Burst of Sunshine on the Sadya leaf.

Ingredients | Serves 4

- 2 cups ripe pineapple, finely chopped
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- 2–3 tbsp grated jaggery, or to taste
- Salt, to taste
- ½ cup fresh grated coconut
- 1–2 green chillies
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- ½ cup thick, fresh yoghurt, whisked
- 1 tsp coconut oil
- ½ tsp mustard seeds
- 1 dried red chilli
- 6–8 curry leaves

Cooking Instructions: Cook pineapple with turmeric, salt and a splash of water until tender. Add jaggery and simmer until melted and excess moisture reduces. Grind coconut, green chillies and cumin into a smooth paste; stir into the pineapple and cook gently for 2–3 minutes.
Cool slightly, then fold in whisked yoghurt without boiling. For tempering, heat coconut oil, splutter mustard seeds, then add dried red chilli and curry leaves. Pour over the pachadi and serve.
The secret is balance: ripe pineapple, just enough jaggery, creamy yoghurt and gentle spice should come together in every spoonful.

Avial — The Soul of a Kerala Sadya:

Ingredients | Serves 4

- 3 cup mix of raw banana, carrot, ash gourd, snake gourd cut into strips
- ½ cup drumstick, French beans cut into 2-inch pieces
- ½ cup yam, peeled and cubed
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- Salt, to taste
- ½ cup freshly grated coconut
- 2–3 green chillies
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- ½ cup thick yoghurt, whisked
- 1 tbsp coconut oil
- 1 sprig curry leaves

Cooking Instructions: Cook the harder vegetables first with turmeric, salt and a little water, adding the softer vegetables later so they remain tender but retain their shape. Grind coconut, green chillies and cumin with a little water into a coarse paste.
Gently mix it into the cooked vegetables and simmer for 2–3 minutes. Remove from the heat and allow it to cool slightly before folding in the whisked yoghurt. Finish with a drizzle of coconut oil and fresh curry leaves.

The secret to good Avial is restraint: never overcook the vegetables or make the gravy watery; each vegetable should remain distinct while sharing the flavours of coconut and yoghurt.

Appam — Kerala's Delicate Lace-Edged Classic

Soft, fluffy in the centre and wonderfully crisp around the edges, Appam is one of Kerala's most loved dishes. Traditionally fermented and cooked in a small curved pan, it pairs beautifully with vegetable stew, egg curry or coconut milk.

Ingredients | Serves 4

- 2 cups raw rice
- ½ cup cooked rice
- ½ cup freshly grated coconut
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- Water, as required

Cooking Instructions: Soak raw rice for 4–5 hours. Drain and grind with cooked rice and coconut into a smooth, slightly thick batter. Cover and leave to ferment naturally for 8–12 hours or overnight.
The next morning, add sugar, salt and enough water to make a light, flowing batter. Heat an Appachatti, pour a ladleful into the centre and swirl gently to spread it towards the edges. Cover and cook until the edges are crisp and lacy while the centre remains soft. Serve hot.

Some recipes are memories waiting to be recreated .

Santhoshathode pachakam cheyyu... snehathode vilambu... ruchiyode aaswadikku!

(Sherry Bhatnagar is a passionate food storyteller with deep roots in Indian regional cuisine, the author writes where memory, migration, and the kitchen intersect. Having lived across cultures yet firmly anchored in Indian flavours, her work explores food not just as nourishment, but as identity, tradition, and lived experience—told with honesty, restraint, and quiet depth.)

September 2026

A Month of Shifts, Realisations & New Directions

Richa Pathak

September carries a thoughtful but active energy. Some of you may finally receive an answer you have been waiting for, while others may realise that the answer was within you all along. This is a month of changing priorities, unfinished matters returning for closure, and making choices with greater maturity.

Aries (Mar 21 – Apr 19)
September may begin with impatience, especially around work or a decision that seems unnecessarily delayed. Don't push just because you dislike waiting. The middle of the month can bring movement through a new contact or an unexpected conversation. In love, choose a calm discussion over proving your point. **Lucky Color:** Terracotta **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Donate red lentils on a Tuesday and avoid unnecessary arguments that day.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
Money and security occupy your thoughts this month. You may be planning a major purchase, property matter or financial commitment. Take your time; a decision made after proper checking will serve you better. Personal relationships become warmer when you stop expecting others to guess what you need. **Lucky Color:** Olive Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Donate white food items such as rice or sugar on Friday to someone who needs them.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
September brings people back into your orbit. An old colleague, friend or professional contact may unexpectedly bring useful information or an opportunity. Your communication skills are particularly strong, but avoid discussing every plan before it has taken shape. Let some things grow quietly. **Lucky Color:** Pale Green **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Donate green moong or stationery to a student on Wednesday.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
You may become more protective of your peace this month, and honestly, that is not a bad thing. A family matter may require your attention, but don't take responsibility for everyone's emotions. Home-related changes or discussions are possible. In love, emotional honesty can heal an old misunderstanding. **Lucky Color:** Ivory **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Spend a few quiet minutes near a water body or your prayer space on Monday and offer a simple prayer for emotional balance.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
You may receive recognition for something you have been doing consistently rather than something you started recently. This is a good month to step into responsibility without feeling the need to dominate every situation. Someone may be waiting for you to make the first move in a personal matter. **Lucky Color:** Antique Gold **Lucky Day:** Sunday **Remedy:** Offer water to the Sun in the morning and begin the day by expressing gratitude rather than making demands.

Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
Your birthday month brings a sharper awareness of what needs to change. You may finally become tired of a routine that has been draining you. This is an excellent time to reorganise your schedule, finances and priorities. Don't wait for everything to become perfect before starting something new. **Lucky Color:** Moss Green **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Donate books, notebooks or useful study material to a student on Wednesday.

Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
September asks you to be honest about your relationships. You may realise that keeping everyone comfortable has sometimes meant keeping yourself unhappy. A partnership, either personal or professional, could reach an important turning point. Speak clearly, but don't speak harshly. **Lucky Color:** Dusty Rose **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Donate white clothing or personal-care essentials to a woman in need on Friday.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
Something you have been emotionally attached to may begin losing its hold over you. This could be a person, an old disappointment or even a professional expectation. Financially, be careful about lending or borrowing based purely on trust. Your instincts are sharp, but verify important matters before acting. **Lucky Color:** Burnt Rust **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Visit a Hanuman temple on Tuesday and offer jaggery and roasted gram if this is part of your regular spiritual practice.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
A change of environment can do wonders for your thinking. Travel, education, a mentor or a new professional circle may introduce you to a different possibility. Don't underestimate a beginning simply because it isn't dramatic. In relationships, say what you feel instead of assuming the other person already understands. **Lucky Color:** Mustard Yellow **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Donate yellow dal or turmeric on Thursday and dedicate the act to someone who helped you grow.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
You may be carrying more than people realise. September asks you to distinguish between genuine responsibility and burdens you have accepted out of habit. A pending professional or financial matter may take time, but steady handling will work in your favour. Make room for rest without feeling guilty. **Lucky Color:** Slate Blue **Lucky Day:** Saturday **Remedy:** Donate black sesame, footwear or essential items to someone in need on Saturday.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
An unusual idea may deserve more attention than you initially think. September supports networking, technology, learning and experimenting with a different approach. Someone may challenge your thinking and that could actually benefit you. In love, a friendship may slowly develop into something more meaningful. **Lucky Color:** Steel Blue **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Feed grains to birds regularly during the month, especially in the morning.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
Your intuition is strong, but September asks you to combine it with practical judgement. You may sense someone's intentions before they say them openly. Career improves when you become stricter about your time and energy. A creative skill could also begin showing financial potential. **Lucky Color:** Seafoam Green **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Keep a small bowl of clean water with fresh basil leaves near your prayer space and replace it regularly.

Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8452920640 & www.jyotishdham.com)